

Off the Shelf



Age of Wonders: Shadow Magic

Shades of wonder

Age of Wonders: Shadow Magic (AoWSM) starts off where Age of Wonders 2 (AoW2) ended. The game lies hesitantly between a full-blown sequel and a shy expansion pack. Missions serve to both progress the tale, and throw a surprise or two into the works.

Merlin has saved the world, but is swallowed by a portal into the parallel realm of the Shadow World. You're required to step into wizardry shoes, specialise in a school of magic or dabble in multiple disciplines, sketch out the characteristics of your domain, and get buddy-buddy with the 15-odd races that share your world, if not your viewpoint.

Save the world... in 16 scenarios!

AoWSM introduces us to the Shadow Demons—a dark race intent upon feasting upon the souls of the living. The opening cinematic shows the wizards as a hunted lot, persecuted by non-magic people who consider them responsible for the emergence of the Shadow Demons.

The single-player campaign is quite long, with five episodes and 16 scenarios. As a bonus to new gamers, it also includes an in-depth tutorial episode. The game includes 19 standalone scenarios, which are shorter and definitely more fast-paced

than the campaign. The game introduces two new races—the roaming Nomads and the mystic Syrons.



Seen here (in a manner of speaking), is the Spirit of War, offering a quest to our hero

Tag, you're It!

Being a turn-based strategy game, the pace is very often tedious. It may sometimes take 20 to 25 turns for a village to transform into a town.

Also, if you build a shrine dedicated to various Spirits, then you'd better have enough resources and a good army to carry out their wishes. The Spirits range from a megalomaniac Spirit of War to an extremist Greenpeace-supporting Spirit of Nature. Their demands can be turned down, but if refused for too long, punishments are quick and severe.

Besides the two new playable races, each race features a new, unique building upgrade and the subsequent unit produced from it. Each of these upgrades allows a unique ability for the city as a whole. The Secret Forest upgrade for the Elves makes their cities almost invisible to enemy scouts and units who mean you harm. A new upgrade available to all races is the Item Forge, where magical items can be custom-built with enchantments of your choice.

The graphics engine is the same as that of AoW2. This is where the developers really have their work cut out. Poor graphics come to the fore in the tactical screens during combat. For example, some of the wall-climbing units, instead of scaling walls, walk right through them!

Do-it-yourself adventuring

On a more soothing note, ambient sounds and background music are very good. Additionally, you can load music tracks of your choice for the in-game playlist by copying MP3s into the game's Songs folder, and enabling the Custom Playlist while playing the game.

Like all good Strategy games, AoWSM has extensive support for multiplayer gaming. Besides the usual support for LAN and the Internet through GameSpy, the game also features the Play-By-E-mail (PBEM) mode that is unique to the series. PBEM allows players to send their moves to each other in turns, via e-mail. This mode is especially suitable for those with slow dial-up connections, as also for hardcore fans and armchair generals alike, who can continue their games for weeks.

The inbuilt map editor is quite simple to use, and now also features a random scenario generator that adds to the replayability of the game. However, the presence of a little detailed help in this section would have been more than welcome. The scenario editor is far more powerful. You can link scenarios together, spruce up your custom maps with introductions and endings, and import pictures to support your concocted stories.

In the end, Age of Wonders: Shadow Magic is still a great game for people new to this genre, as well as hardcore fans, despite the poor graphics.



This fat pig happens to be the villain of the piece. Doesn't look like it, but trust us. He's evil

Genre: Strategy ■ **Developer:** Triumph Studios ■ **Publisher:** Gathering ■ **System Requirements:** 400 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, 800 MB hard drive space, DirectX 9.0a ■ **Price:** NA ■ **Web site:** www.ageofwonders.com
Rating: ★★★★★